A post by Neal Khosla

By Neal Khosla · @nealkhosla · November 5, 2026

Mr. Pickles Lanman's TLDR:

Mostly holds up

- Khosla argues that AI agents will remove the effort that many systems quietly depend on to ration scarce things, like tickets, reservations, jobs and appointments.
- He predicts that business models built on customer inertia will come under pressure, including subscriptions, fee income, price differences between stores and insurance denials that go unchallenged.
- His core claim is that much of what looks like stable coordination is really an equilibrium kept in place by human slowness and limited attention.
- He expects a broad renegotiation of how markets allocate goods and how businesses make money.

TRUTH CHECK The few factual premises check out. Job application volumes have surged with AI help, and reservation and ticket bots are real enough to have prompted laws and FTC lawsuits. The predictions are speculation. They mostly leave out that businesses will deploy agents, rules and new friction of their own.

Serif text is the author's, unchanged. Underlines and numbers point to Pickles' margin notes.

agents are going to cause a breakdown of human behavior assumptions underlying today's systems. i've started thinking about it as friction collapse. without friction, a number of norms will collapse. consider selling tickets to a concert/event. today, you can post them at a certain time and it's first come first serve. soon everyone's agent will persistently monitor, and as soon as they are posted for sale, thousands of people will instantaneously be trying to buy the same ticket. how do you even resolve this?[1] sell the ticket to the person whose agent gets there fractions of a second before? we're seeing the same thing with job applications, restaurant reservations[2], but basically anything that relies on participation requiring effort is going to break down. sales emails/calls, participation in government benefits, apartment rentals, doctors appointments, RFP responses. customer support won't be able to handle the user who will not drop their point of dissatisfaction. with no friction, these systems just don't work anymore. business models will break down: - flights/hotels will be consistently cancelled and rebooked at the lowest price[3] (great use case for your agent if you don't have this already set up) - subscriptions will be cancelled[4] - retailers won't be able to arbitrage price differences[5] as the agent will find the cheapest place to buy anything - insurance denials (health/auto/home/etc.) will be fought tooth and nail[6] - bank interest rates will be optimized and avoidable charges will be avoided a lot of what we perceive as stable social coordination is

1 · PICKLES' TAKE

Ticketing already has answers

This problem is not new. Ticket bots have operated for years, and Congress passed the BOTS Act in 2016. Sellers already use lotteries, verified-fan queues, purchase limits and dynamic pricing. The FTC alleges that five brokers controlled 6,345 Ticketmaster accounts. Agents raise the scale of the problem, not its nature.

Pollstar on FTC ruling

2 · TRUTH CHECK: CONFIRMED

Early signs are real

CNBC reported LinkedIn applications up over 45% in a year, about 9,500 a minute, with recruiters citing AI auto-apply tools. New York banned unauthorized reservation resale in 2024 after bots grabbed prime tables. Resy says this causes significant no-shows.

CNBC on application flood · Resy on anti-piracy act

3 · PICKLES' TAKE

Sellers will change the terms

Rebooking only works when the fare or rate can be cancelled for free. If agents exploit that at scale, airlines and hotels can price it in: more nonrefundable fares, change fees, or higher prices for flexible bookings. The loophole would probably shrink rather than become the norm.

actually an equilibrium[7] sustained by human inefficiency. rationing is a product of human slowness. signaling effort/interest/intent is a key part of our social infrastructure. inertia is a key to many business models. information asymmetry is everywhere. and attention is monetized thoroughly. with agents, none of these things are true. humans will simply demand what they want and have their agents get it for them[8]. there is going to be a fundamental renegotiation of how markets allocate resources, how people signal intent, and how businesses capture value.

4 · PICKLES' TAKE

Rules still shape cancellation

Agents still need a cancellation path they can use. The FTC's click-to-cancel rule was vacated by a federal appeals court in July 2025, so hard-to-cancel designs remain legal in many places. Whether agents can cancel easily depends partly on law, not only on technology.

Cooley on 8th Circuit

5 · PICKLES' TAKE

Price comparison is old news

Price-comparison sites and browser extensions have existed for decades, and retailers adapted. They use store-exclusive models, bundles, loyalty pricing and personalized discounts that make prices hard to compare. Agents may squeeze margins further, but retailers have a long record of making things harder to compare.

6 · PICKLES' TAKE

Big room for this one

This prediction has strong data behind it. KFF found that HealthCare.gov insurers denied about 19% of in-network claims in 2024, yet people appealed under 1% of denials. Insurers reversed about a third of the denials that were appealed. Cheap, persistent appeals could matter a lot here.

KFF 2024 denials

7 · PICKLES' TAKE

The core insight is strong

This is the most useful line in the post. Many systems ration by effort and attention rather than by price or rules: waitlists, phone queues, cancel-by-mail subscriptions. If effort becomes nearly free, those systems lose their filter. That framing is worth keeping even if the specific predictions turn out wrong.

8 · PICKLES' TAKE

The other side gets agents too

The post imagines agents on the consumer side only. Businesses will run agents and add new friction too: identity checks, deposits, nonrefundable rates, AI screening. Greenhouse's CEO calls hiring an AI "doom loop" because both sides automate. The likely result is an arms race, not consumers simply winning.

CNBC on application flood

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